

THE HOME
SUNSHINE
SERIES

BOOKS FOR BOYS

A decorative illustration of red flowers and leaves, positioned above the title.

THE · GOOD · SHIP
· ROVER ·

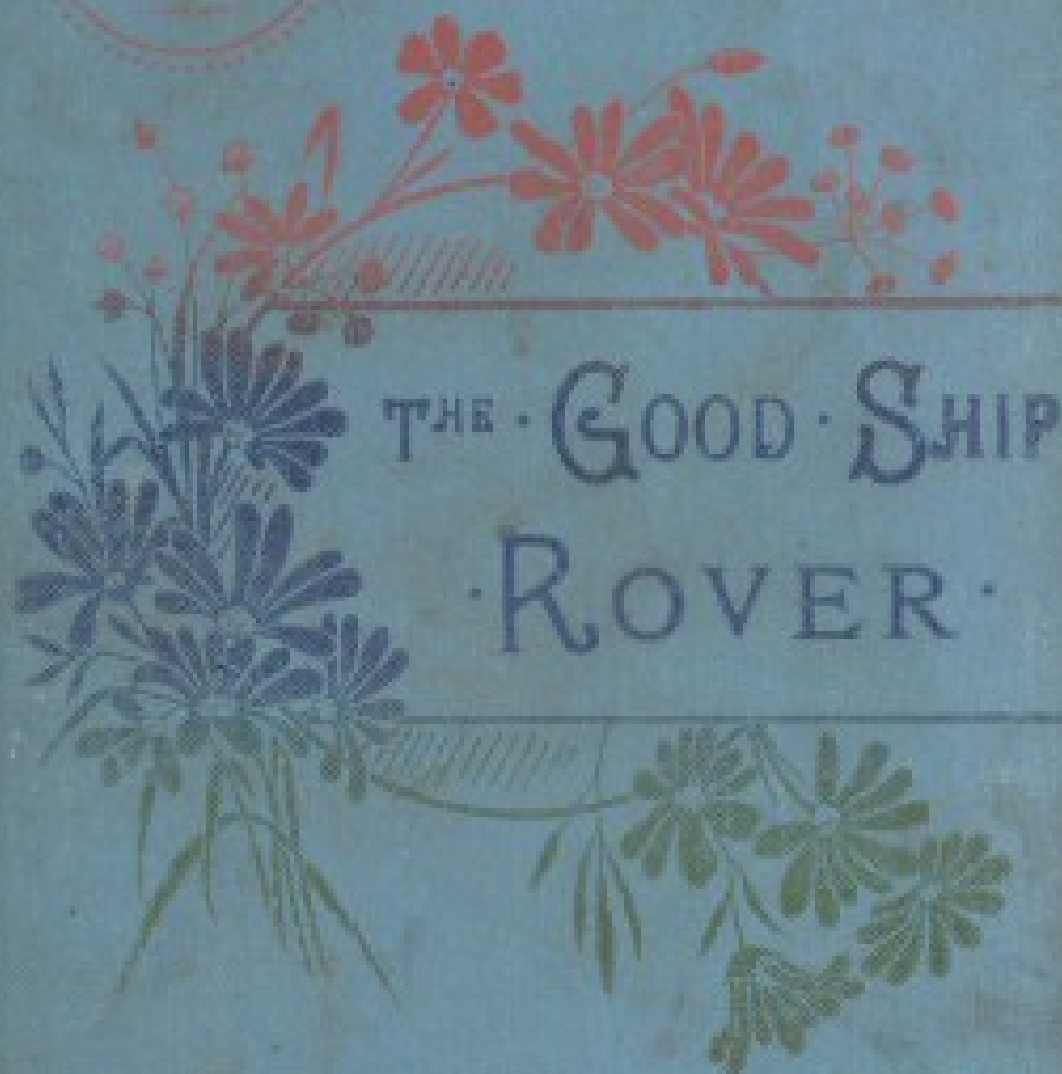
A decorative illustration of green flowers and leaves, positioned below the title.

BY ROBINA F. HARDY



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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE GOOD
SHIP ROVER ***

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THE GOOD SHIP “ROVER.”

T. NELSON AND SONS.
London, Edinburgh, and New York.

I. HIGH AND DRY.

A gallant ship, some three feet in length, with full equipment of white sails and sturdy masts, rigging, pennon, and figurehead; but it had never seen the sea—never! It had “cast anchor” nearly a year before my story begins in the Leslie’s nursery—a very pleasant, airy room, with nice pictures on the wall and a good many toys scattered about, but certainly not the very least resembling the sea. In fact, I don’t think Mrs. Leslie would have liked if it had resembled it; for she was very much afraid of the children being near a lake or a pond even, on account of the dangers of damp feet and catching cold—two evils which always haunted her mind more or less. She was rather a delicate creature, often ailing,—which, perhaps, was the reason of these nervous fancies; and most of the children resembled their mother in this, that there was sure to be something the matter with one or other of them most days of the week. The doctor was seldom long out of the house. Fortunately, Dr. Hammond lived just next door, so he was easily sent for; and Walter Hammond, the doctor’s eldest boy, was Harry Leslie’s dearest and most intimate friend. The two boys were about eight years old, went to the same school, spent most of their play-hours together, and intended both to go to the sea together when they were old enough. For Harry Leslie, though he had never once seen the sea any more than his ship had done, had heard and read a great deal about sailor life and adventures, and had inspired Walter with the same admiration for these as he himself felt. Besides, his uncle Jack, Mr. Leslie’s brother, who had made the ship for his little nephew, had often told him stories about the sea which he treasured in his heart all the more, perhaps, because he was so often mured up by his nursery walls, or even in his little iron bed, on account of colds, coughs, measles, chicken-pox, etc.

Walter Hammond, unlike his friend, was a strong, bright, merry little fellow, never a day in the house or away from school; but he was very fond of Harry all the same. Walter had only two sisters and then a baby-brother, all

of whom were rather young for him to play with, so he spent a great deal of his leisure time in the Leslie's nursery. What scores of times had Harry and Walter studied and examined the *Rover*! They had taken down its sails and its rigging and its masts over and over again. They knew every inch of its planks, every nail and screw about its framework. And how often they had spoken about the delight of launching it in "real live water," in the wide blue sea perhaps! That would be something worth living for.

Harry and Walter were in the same class at Dr. Grierson's Academy in Rosehampton, and very good scholars both were. One or other was pretty sure to be at the top most days, and if Walter was first, Harry would be not far off, and *vice versa*.

One day, however, the rest of the boys were very much amused at some strange mistakes made by these duxes. Harry having been told to mention some chief towns in Asia Minor, rashly began with "Kingshaven," and then corrected himself, blushing and looking very much ashamed, while Dr. Grierson himself had some difficulty in subduing the bursts of laughter all down the forms.

Then Walter, who had been called upon to stand up and give some account of the appearance and structure of a steam-engine, astonished everybody by saying it had "*two masts*!"

That day the inseparable friends were very much lower down in the class than they were accustomed to be, and it required no little effort on their part during the succeeding days to prevent their thoughts from wandering, and to keep them fixed on the more dry and uninteresting subjects of their lesson.

The younger Leslie's were also much excited about going to the sea-side; but visions of shell-gathering, digging in the sands, and such mild pursuits, were quite enough for them; and, indeed, they knew so little about the sea that they had no materials whereof to form any more brilliant plans. As to bathing, they were rather frightened about that, considering that it must be something like going into the green nursery tub, but with very cold water to wash in!

Walter had been at Margate once with his father, and could describe the sea to Harry in very lively terms. The sands, the bathing-coaches, the rocks, the billows—nothing was forgotten in Walter’s narratives. But, alas! the little town of Rosehampton, where they lived, was very far away from any part of this enchanting ocean, and for long there seemed no chance whatever of Mrs. Leslie consenting to let her children brave the perils of a month’s residence near the sea.

“I like them to go to the country,” she would say to her husband or the doctor, who often recommended sea-air, “and to think of them running about on the grass when it is dry and sunny; for it is very close and airless sometimes here in Diamond Terrace in the long summer days. But do let me keep to dry land. It makes me quite nervous to think of Harry falling over the rocks or getting into boats, and Bobby and Frank getting their feet wet constantly on the shore when they are so subject to bronchitis.”

“Pooh, pooh, my dear!” her husband would say, “you are far too much afraid of these children getting into danger. It makes them little molly-coddles, indeed it does.” But he was an easy-going man, who let his wife do pretty much as she liked, and did not interfere with her management of house or children.

“Mamma,” said Harry one day, “how is it that Uncle Jack *never* catches cold?—and, besides, he has never been drowned.”

“Hush, Harry; don’t talk so rashly. You don’t know what may happen to your uncle yet. And I do wish he wouldn’t tell you all those long stories about the sea when he comes; they make me quite miserable.”

“I like them *awfully*, mamma,” cried Harry, “and so does Walter. And do you know, mamma, Walter and I are both going to be sailors when we grow big. Only I do wish we might sail the *Rover* first in real sea-water; it would look so splendid!”

“Well, Harry, be a good boy,” said his mother, who did not like to disappoint her boy more than was for his good, “and don’t go on talking about being a sailor, for that you shall never be. Your papa and I will never hear of it. As to Walter, his father may do what he pleases; but you are going to help your father in the warehouse when you grow big, so you don’t

need to trouble your head about anything else. But, as I was saying, if you are a good boy till next holidays, I promise to take you all to Kingshaven, and you shall sail your ship as much as you like from the little jetty or the rocks. It is a nice safe place with lovely sands—if the sea ever can be said to be *safe*.”

Harry listened in silent amazement to these words. The utter crushing of his hopes as to sailor-life was for the moment completely forgotten in the near and enchanting prospect held out to him in its place. But he was a kind-hearted, affectionate boy, and even in this hour of excitement he did not forget his friend.

“But Walter, mamma?” he cried, as his mother was leaving the room, —“how can I sail it without Walter?”

“Well, you can ask Walter to come with us. I daresay he will be very glad,” said his mother, calling back from the staircase, for she was in a hurry about some household affair.

Harry clapped his hands, and ran to tell Walter, who was equally overjoyed at the idea of going to Kingshaven with Harry. So they set to work and counted the weeks and days that must elapse until the holidays came round, and then they once more thoroughly overhauled the “good ship *Rover*” to see if it was water-tight and ready for its first voyage.

It would be literally its first voyage. Harry and Walter had tried the green tub that belonged to the nursery, but in vain. It was not nearly long enough. Cook would not let them try the fixed tubs in the laundry, and it was very doubtful if even they would have held the *Rover*.

The bath would have done so easily, and longing eyes had often been fixed on it with that idea. But Mrs. Leslie was inexorable—no such dabbling among water, either hot or cold, was to be permitted; so the *Rover* still stuck high and dry in the nursery window.

II. THE SEA! THE SEA!

The midsummer holidays at last came round, and Mrs. Leslie, who had been busy packing up and arranging things for some weeks, now resolved to shut up the house for a whole month and, with the family, set off for Kingshaven.

It was a long way off—some thirty or forty miles—so it was quite like an adventure to Harry Leslie and his little brothers and sisters, and scarcely less so to Walter Hammond, who was to accompany them. Dr. Hammond could not leave home on account of his numerous patients; and had it not been for this fine chance, Walter would have had only a few days in the country now and then. He was a good-tempered, sensible boy, and a pleasant guest in any household. Mr. Leslie would be able to go down with his family to Kingshaven; but was to leave them there and return to business, making his home for the time at a married sister's house in Rosehampton. So everything seemed promising; and even Mrs. Leslie, naturally of a most anxious and troubled disposition, set off with hardly a cloud on her horizon.

Harry had been very active in helping his mother all the day before the departure, and once when carrying a heavy box down from the attics he had felt it bump heavily against his knee; but being a brave little boy, he said and thought nothing about it at the time. All through the afternoon and night, however, a strange, dull pain in the knee haunted him. He did not tell anybody, but he wished frequently it would go away before he got to Kingshaven. There stood the *Rover*, all nicely packed and ready for the railway journey, and Harry's heart beat high when he thought how soon he should see it riding proudly on the waves—the admired of all beholders.

Harry wakened early on the Saturday morning that had been fixed for their journey with this bright vision before his eyes; but a sudden shoot of pain,

as he moved his knee, made him fall back on his pillow and almost scream for help. He controlled himself, however, and began to examine again the wounded spot. There was a swelling; but the blue and black marks he had seen last night were nearly gone. The thing had rather too white a look; but Harry took this for a good sign, and hoped it would be all right before long. He got up and dressed, slowly and with difficulty, and still concealed even from his mother's sharp eyes that anything was wrong. Walter came round early, and in time the whole party were off.

After a long but pleasant journey they reached the busy little sea-side resort of Kingshaven—a brisk, rising town, greatly patronized by families in search of bathing and safe boating and other marine enjoyments. Briery Cottage, which Mrs. Leslie had hired for the month, was very satisfactory in every way but one. It stood so far up in the town and in such a position that no view of the sea whatever, not even the tiniest bit, was to be obtained from its windows. That was a drawback certainly; and as they had only chosen it from an advertisement, they had not taken this point into consideration. It could not be helped now.

“Well, it does not much matter, after all,” said Mrs. Leslie. “You children will be all day long on the beach; and as for me, if I take my knitting down to the rocks all the afternoons, I shall see as much of the sea as I want to. You know I am not so much in love with it as you all are.”

Briery Cottage, though it did not command a sea-view, was a very nice, comfortable little cottage, with a pleasant garden in front and a long strip of bowling-green behind. In front passed the wide public road, with many carriages and other vehicles constantly coming and going; so it could not be called a dull place at all events.

“O mamma, what a nice place Kingshaven is!” said Harry, quite enthusiastically. “I'm sure I should never weary here even if we were to stay for a whole year!”

“Not even if you didn't see the sea, Harry?” asked his father, laughing.

“Oh, but that would be impossible, you know, papa!” answered Harry.

Harry was to have a longer time at Kingshaven than he imagined, and perhaps if he could have foreseen everything he would not have talked so

very confidently of “*never* wearying.” But it is very good for all of us that just one step of our way is open before us. It helps to make us humble and trustful, looking for guidance better and higher than our own, and may often preserve us from being needlessly downcast and depressed.

Mr. and Mrs. Leslie were very glad to see all their children so well and bright and so pleased with the holiday treat they had provided for them.

“I must come down on Monday morning to the shore before going home,” Mr. Leslie said to the boys as he saw them carrying their boat, “and see the good ship *Rover*’s first voyage. It will be quite a sight!”

“Oh, we are all coming!” added his wife. “I assure you none of us would like to miss the spectacle; and if none of the little ones fall over the rocks, I’m sure everything will go well!”

By the time they got thoroughly settled in their new home it was getting quite late in the day, so there was only time for a saunter all along the beach and the parade and the principal streets of Kingshaven. It was with some difficulty that Harry managed to walk now; but so anxious was he to secure his grand treat on Monday that he still kept his pain to himself. Walter and he had selected one delightful rock, stretching far out into the sea, from which to make the first launch and trial trip of the *Rover*. There were lots of little boys already there, and on similar rocks, sailing their tiny boats, but none of them had anything the least like the *Rover*.

“We’ll call it a pirate ship, Wat,” cried Harry excitedly, “and it will be grand to see it chasing the little boats all about. What a splendid thing the sea is! I wish we could stay always beside it.”

Walter agreed to all Harry said.

“Yes,” he said, “that will be the very thing. The *Rover* is the very name for a pirate ship, you know. Let’s be up in good time on Monday morning, Harry, and be down here for a first venture by ourselves, in case it doesn’t work right just at the very first, you know, and people might laugh.”

So the two boys chatted and planned while Mr. and Mrs. Leslie and the rest sallied on in front. But Harry was not sorry when his mother gave the order for everybody to go home and get to bed, so as to have a good wash—it

being Saturday night—and a good sound sleep before Sunday; for Mrs. Leslie was a good mother, and loved to teach her children to observe the Lord's day rightly, and to enjoy it in a way worthy of its sacred rest. The Leslies all liked going with their parents to church. It was never thought a weariness or a punishment even by the youngest. They could not, of course, understand all that was said and done there, but they learned to sit quietly and reverently while their elders listened, which was in itself a valuable training for after life; and there were many portions of the service which they could appreciate for themselves. Mr. Leslie always liked them to say over the text and the psalms and hymns they had heard, and this was looked forward to by the youngsters as quite a pleasant exercise.

But we must go on with the story.

“What are you thinking about, Harry?” said his mother as she bustled about, getting Bobby and Frank, Lucy and Janey, washed and dried and put to bed in the tiny nursery at Briery Cottage, which indeed was very different from the one they had left at Rosehampton, though, with the usual happy taste of children, Lucy and Janey thought their narrow cribs ever so much nicer than the home ones; while Bobby and Frank considered the two skylights here infinitely preferable to the large bow-window they were accustomed to.

Harry was sitting in a contemplative manner upon a trunk on the landing below, Walter having preceded him upstairs.

“Run after Walter and see that you two boys have a good scrub. The bath is ready for you; and see you don't hang about after it to catch cold, but get into Blanket Bay as fast as you can. I'm sure I feel quite ready for it myself after all that trudging about over sands and rocks.”

Thus admonished, Harry made his way upstairs to the back attic, where Walter and he and the *Rover* were moored.

III. “BLANKET BAY.”

Early next morning Walter Hammond knocked at Mrs. Leslie’s door.

“Could you come and look at Harry’s knee?” he asked in rather a frightened voice. “We think there is something wrong with it.”

Mrs. Leslie lost no time, you may be sure. And here, sure enough, she found poor Harry lying in excruciating pain, and with a great white swelling on his knee, which her experienced eyes saw at once was no ordinary bruise or sprain.

“My boy!” she cried, “why didn’t you tell me sooner? If I had only known!”

Harry could not help his tears flowing fast now. It had been such a long strain upon him to keep up hour after hour, that it was quite a relief at last to have the very worst fully confessed.

“I thought it would go off, mamma,” he said, “or I would have told. And I was so anxious to be well just now, for the sea; and oh, I can’t move one single step!”

“Don’t cry, dear. We’ll send for the doctor and see what he says. I daresay he will make it better before long. And you mustn’t fret, you know, or you’ll make yourself worse.” So saying, Mrs. Leslie had the nearest medical man sent for, and the little patient laid neatly and comfortably in bed—as her skilful hands could well do.

Dr. Bell came, and pronounced poor Harry’s a very grave case of what is popularly known as “white swelling,” brought on by the hurt he had received, but chiefly owing to the little boy’s very delicate system. “He must lie quite still for some weeks at least,” said the doctor. “There must be no trying to get up or move about until I give permission.”

Poor Harry! it was indeed a hard and bitter trial, and he did not then know that he would yet be thankful one day for a lesson taught him by this very trouble. But, indeed, we very seldom know such things till the time of trial is long past.

Walter was removed to a sofa-bed in the parlour, so as to give Harry more room and air, since the little attic must be his sole abode for long weeks in all probability.

And so it proved. Harry lay there day after day, hardly daring even to sit half up in bed for meals, and compelled to lie mostly on his back. There stood the unfortunate ship *Rover*, whose piratical wanderings had also been cruelly frustrated. It stood on a table just below the skylight, so that Harry could see it easily where he lay; but now the sight rather added to his vexation than otherwise. Would he ever be able to sail it before they left Kingshaven and returned to Rosehampton? It seemed very unlikely.

Their kind friend Dr. Hammond came down at once on hearing of Harry's illness—which was of course a great comfort, as he knew so well about his little patient; but he only confirmed Dr. Bell's verdict, and declared Harry must continue in the quiet quarters of "Blanket Bay," as his mother called it. The unfortunate thing of *this* Blanket Bay was that it did not look to the sea, nor indeed to anything but the sky.

The days passed wonderfully, however. Harry was fond of reading, and plenty of nice books were got for him; the younger children were, of course, perfectly happy digging houses and castles in the sand; and Walter did the best he could to amuse himself companionless, or with any boys who seemed friendly and ready to play with him. He did all he could to amuse Harry, too, by coming home with stories of all he had seen, and would sit for hours on the bedside chatting to him, if allowed; but Mrs. Leslie said it was very wrong to waste his holidays that way, and generally packed him off to the shore again.

Harry Leslie knew that to Walter as well as to himself it was a great disappointment not to see the *Rover* floated. He thought over it many a time, and being a kind-hearted boy in general, it did vex him not a little that Walter also should be disappointed. But the idea of his telling Walter to take the *Rover* down himself to the rocks, and have the delight of seeing it

ride proudly on the waves—oh, that was too much for Harry! If the idea ever did really present itself plainly to his mind as a thing that might be done—and I am not at all sure that it did—then it was put aside at once as a plan quite ridiculous and not to be encouraged. Harry had read of Sir Philip Sidney passing the cup of water from his own parched lips to the dying-soldier who had still greater need of it than himself, and he had thought it a grand and beautiful action; but then it had never occurred to him that in his own little common life—the every-day life of home and school, or it might be sick-room—deeds of the *same kind of heroism*, though not by any means so likely to be spoken of, were possible to and even required of him and every one who wished to lead a brave and noble life.

It was not till nearly a fortnight had come and gone—half the time they were to spend at Kingshaven—that some words of his father's set Harry thinking of this very subject, and the thing struck him as it had never done before.

Mr. Leslie had come down at the end of the week, as he always did, to spend Sunday with his family, and to see how his little sick boy was getting on. He stood looking at the *Rover* for a little that Saturday night, and then said before leaving the room,—

“By-the-by, you’ve never got your grand ship sailed yet. What will Uncle Jack say when he hears of it? But let me see. Couldn’t Watty there sail it? It’s a sort of pity he shouldn’t have some pleasure out of it, isn’t it?”

“O papa!” cried Harry as if in pain.

“Why, what is it?” said his father, alarmed at the crimson colour rising in his son’s face. “Is the knee so painful, my man?”

“No, no, papa,” said Harry, rather abashed; “I was thinking of what you said. You know it is *my* ship—my very own. How *could* I let Walter or any one else sail it, when I can’t even look out and see it, you know?”

Mr. Leslie was greatly surprised by this speech, but he was a good-natured, easy-going man, as has been said, never liking to cross or disappoint anybody if he could help it, and the sight of his poor little Harry lying there perhaps weighed against his own better judgment.

“Ah! I see,” he said. “You don’t like it to go out of your own hands. Well, you must just act ‘dog in the manger’ if you will, my boy. It is for yourself to judge. I never meddle with other people’s affairs, whether about toys or big things! You shall do exactly as you like with your boat, my boy; and I daresay it won’t be so very long before you and Walter will be able to go down to the beach together. By-the-by, did I tell you I met Dr. Grierson, and he was asking most kindly for his little scholar—quite sorry to hear of your being laid up, Harry? And the young Melvilles are perhaps coming down to Kingshaven before long. You’ll like to see them again. Jack Lowford had a nasty fall off that bicycle of his. He was coming down Grove Lane, where it is rather steep, you know, and the thing went right over. Jack cut his head badly against the big gray stone at Mr. Sheffard’s gate, and had to be taken into the house and doctored up a bit before he could go home. Very kind people these Sheffards are, I must say.—But here comes Wat, who will give you news of the beach more interesting than mine. So good-night, my boy, and see that you sleep sound.”

So saying Mr. Leslie left him to repose

IV. FAIRLY AFLOAT.

Harry Leslie lay long awake that night, thinking over the words his father had carelessly enough dropped. "Dog in the manger"—what did that mean exactly? He had heard the phrase more than once, but had never stopped to consider it in any way. Yet it was a plain sort of illustration, carrying its own meaning along with it. Harry had once been staying in the country with some cousins at a farm-house called Clover Hollow, and he remembered them all laughing one day at "Grip," a little Skye terrier, that had got into one of the mangers in the stable, and kept at a respectable distance the good old pony to which it belonged, barking at him and refusing to allow him the enjoyment of his own breakfast. And Grip could not, of course, enjoy it himself—chopped hay and oats not being at all in *his* line. Seemingly, the only pleasure Grip derived from this performance lay in keeping "Donald," the old pony, from having any breakfast! And it was very laughable at the time. Yes; Harry understood the words perfectly. And though it had been laughable enough in the case of Grip, which was only a terrier, still, however clever he might have been thought, Harry felt that it was not quite the same when practised by rational beings. True, he was only keeping that which most clearly belonged only to himself, whereas Master Grip had feloniously seized on the possession of another. There was that difference, certainly. Still, there was something in the thing Harry did not quite like. He was usually a kind, unselfish sort of boy, and he did not enjoy feeling that he was doing something rather miserly now. And then, just that evening, his mother had been reading some verses from the Bible to him, as she usually did, and one of them had been: "Whatsoever ye would that men should do to you, do ye even so to them." He had not thought much about the words at the time, but they came back to his memory now.

Early next morning Harry sent for Walter to come and speak to him.

“Wat,” he said very cheerily, “the *Rover* is going to make its first voyage to-day. Hurrah! Aren’t you glad?”

Walter stared at his friend and wondered if he had grown suddenly worse, and was talking nonsense through feverishness.

“I doubt they won’t let you out to the beach just yet, Hal!” he said soothingly.

“No, indeed!” said Harry, smiling brightly. “But *you* are going to take the ship down for me, and launch her, and all that. Bobby and Frank will go too, of course, and the girls, if nurse can take them; and then you’ll come back and tell me all about it—won’t you, Wat?”



“Nonsense, Harry, nonsense!” cried his friend. “Why, we *couldn’t* do it without you; it would be no fun at all. Your own ship too. No, you needn’t say another word about it.”

But Harry kept to his purpose; and in time Walter felt that he was really quite in earnest, and that to refuse would only vex him.

“Well, if you really want me to, Harry,” he said reluctantly. “But won’t you be awfully dull when I take the good ship away from your room? You’ve often said it was quite a companion to you when we’re all out.”

“Not a bit!” cried Harry bravely. “I’m quite tired of seeing the old thing on dry land. I’m wearying awfully to know how it floats, and you’ll come home and tell me all about it. Tell me if there were people looking on, and if the pennons looked well when they were waving out at sea, and all that. I want to hear what everybody says about it, and if they think the *Rover* as fine a boat as they have ever seen at the Shelf Rock before. So you see, Wat, you must make haste and be off with it, or I’ll be quite put out, and that will be sure to make me worse again. Ask mamma if that isn’t true! I wonder I never thought of this before. It was awfully stupid of me, to be sure!”

His eyes sparkled brightly now, all the brighter, perhaps, because he had just dashed away some childish tears; for he was very young, you must remember, and also weak from illness. He wanted to make his tiny bit of self-sacrifice right bravely and cheerfully, feeling that a grudging manner of giving sadly mars a gift.

Mr. and Mrs. Leslie were greatly pleased at hearing what Harry had planned for the others, especially as it had come entirely from himself. He had certainly not been urged to do it in any way; it had not even been suggested to him.



Well, a large and enthusiastic crowd of juveniles gathered round the Shelf Rock that afternoon to watch the good ship *Rover* make her first voyage on the deep. And beautifully indeed did she spread her white sails to the breeze, while, guided by a string secured in Walter's hand, her graceful form cut the waves or danced lightly over them, her bright red pennons floating gracefully from stern and mast. It was quite a long time before the excitement of this first voyage wore away. Each of the children had in turn to get a "hold" of the guiding-string; and great amusement was caused by one of the wooden-doll sailors which Mrs. Leslie had dressed for Harry's ship tumbling overboard and bobbing about for a long time among the creeks and crannies of Shelf Rock.

At last "Jack-a-tar" was rescued by means of a hand-net which Walter had for his natural history researches; and the little man was found to be not a whit the worse, except for a drenching of his blue serge suit—for even his well-glued-on hat had survived the fury of the waves.

You can imagine what a grand story all this made to tell poor Harry, lying in his little bed under the skylight, with his back to the sea and all the wonders thereof. And no one was more delighted with the whole affair than Harry

himself, feeling quite a weight off his mind, now that he had got quit for ever of that nasty “dog-in-the-manger” sort of feeling. How he laughed about poor Jack-a-tar, and took him into his own hands to be thoroughly restored, while his mother took off the blue suit to dry at the kitchen fire!

Altogether this was one of the happiest days Harry had spent at Kingshaven. Every day now the children took out the *Rover*, and many happy hours they all spent with it.

Next week a visitor was announced. It was Uncle Jack himself! And along with him came the biggest, bulkiest parcel you could imagine. When it was opened it proved to be a first-rate sort of invalid carriage, capable of being folded up or out in any and every direction—quite an invention of Uncle Jack’s own brilliant genius. Dr. Bell said it was the very thing for his little patient, who would be able for it in a very few days now. Dr. Hammond also was greatly pleased with this new conveyance when he came down.

Various little trial trips were made in this couch, at first only into the front garden, and then into the long strip of bowling-green at the back. And how the little invalid *did* enjoy the fresh, sweet summer air, fragrant with honeysuckle and sweet-brier, and all the more delightful to him from the whiff of strong salt and even *tar* corning up from the shore. Harry felt as if he should soon be well and strong again if he were only to have such nice rides as this every day.

At first his knee did pain him considerably even at the least motion; but gradually, as he gained in health and strength, this wore away, and he could be drawn quite a long distance and then left out in some nice sheltered spot, with his book beside him, just to drink in the health-giving breezes.

Uncle Jack’s own strong steady hand was usually the one which drew him about for many days. It seemed to please the kindly sailor to do as much for his little nephew. And no one could pull the chair so well, Harry thought, for he never felt much pain when Uncle Jack was in charge. But by-and-by Walter was allowed to try his skill at it, and very proud and happy he was to try. The best days were those when Harry could be taken right down to the shore and set upon one of the more sheltered rocks; but that was only when the weather was very dry and sunny and there was not too much wind for the patient.

One very fine afternoon, however, quite a large party assembled at the Shelf Rock. There was Harry in his couch, laid snugly in the centre of the group, Bobby and Freddy, Janey and Lucy dancing round him, mamma with a large basket of good things encamped close by, and papa, Uncle Jack, Walter, and good Dr. Hammond, all there to enjoy the family “*picnic!*” But before the feast was spread the good ship *Rover* was to be launched once more, and that was done by Uncle Jack’s well-skilled hands, after which he put the guiding-string in Harry’s white little hand and bade him hold it firm. Harry’s eyes sparkled and his colour mounted; for he felt the full pleasure of this moment, free from any mean or selfish thought.

After all this Mr. Leslie began to think it would be best just to let Harry remain all the summer at Kingshaven, so he secured another cottage nearer the sea than their present quarters; and here Harry remained, and the children by turns, with nurse to keep order, and the parents looking down now and again to see that all was right. Walter had, of course, to go back to school, and he was dux every day now since Harry was off the field. However, next year Harry managed quite to make up to him again, being ever so much stronger then; and in due time the two boys went to Rugby together, remaining fast friends as before.

But we are going on too fast.

Let us look back first to the little seaside cottage where Harry is so happy—never wearying of Kingshaven, as indeed he had declared he never would, even when he knew not how long his stay was to be. He is taken out to the beach every day by careful hands, and is gathering strength bit by bit. Often he is carried over to the Shelf Rock, from there to guide with his own hand the beautiful gliding movements of his pretty ship. Harry feels that this past time of trial has been a blessing to him, since it has saved him from growing into a grasping or selfish boy; and he looks back with pleasure on a sight he did not see—the first voyage of

THE GOOD SHIP “ROVER.”

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE GOOD SHIP
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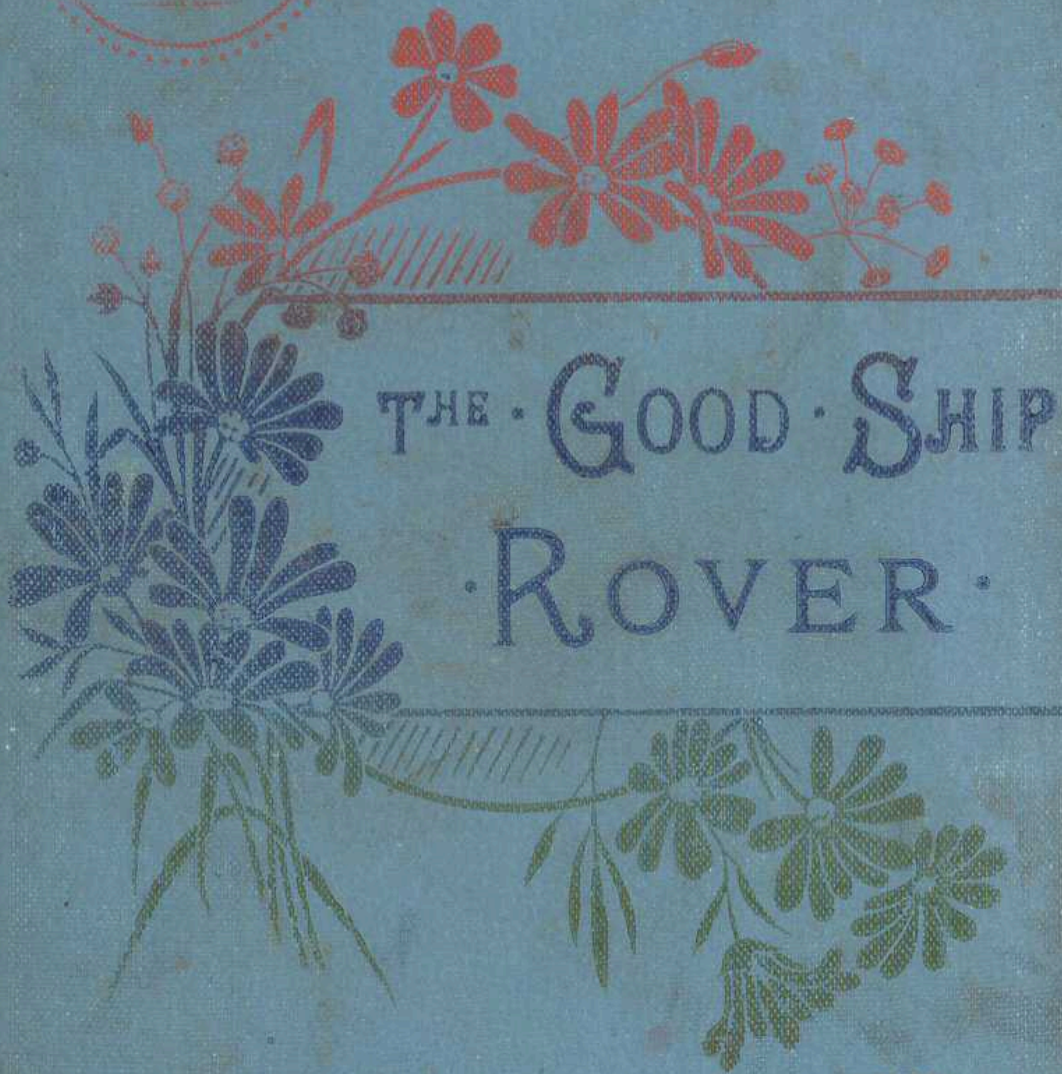
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